PHYS7101 · In-class assessment 1: what to expect

Week 6 lab, Monday 9 November 2026 · 5% of the module · a 5–8 minute conversation about your own work

What it is

A short conversation with a member of staff (Aneta or one of the PGTAs) about the work you are doing at the moment. In Week 6 that will almost certainly be **Exercise 2**: by then you should have done at least Tasks 1–3. If you have barely started Exercise 2, you can talk about a lab notebook you have worked through (Week 4 or Week 5) instead.

It is not a test of whether your answers are right, and you won't be asked to write code. We want to hear **what you did, why you chose to do it that way, and what you would do next**.

What to bring

- Your **Exercise 2 notebook, open and already run**, so the outputs are visible: on your own laptop, or on the lab computer you're working at.
- Your **logbook**, if you keep a separate one. If your notes are in the notebook itself (the *Working log* cell at the top of the Exercise 2 notebook, or Markdown cells between your code), that's fine: we will go through the notebook with you.

What we will ask about

The conversation covers three areas, which are the marking criteria:

Area	For example
Your analysis choices (including your code and figures)	"Talk me through this plot: what is it telling you?" · "Why did you choose that rule, or that value? What else did you try?" · "Show me where in your code that happens."
Your understanding of the method	"What does this function actually do?" · "What does this method assume? When would it give the wrong answer?" · "How do you know this result is right?"
Where you go next	"What are you least sure about, and how would you check it?" · "What would you do next, and why?"

We will pick the questions from what is in your notebook, so every conversation is different and there is nothing to learn by heart.

How to prepare (about 20 minutes)

1. Make sure your notebook runs up to where you have got to.
2. Add a few dated notes in the *Working log* (or your logbook): what you tried, what you expected, what happened, what you decided and why, **and what didn't work**. It's fine to write these up now for work you have already done.
3. Pick **one thing you're pleased with** and **one thing you're stuck on or unsure about**. You may be asked about either.

Being stuck is fine. A clear explanation of what you tried, why it didn't work and what you would try next is worth as much as a finished task.

How it is marked

Each of the three areas is placed in a band on the University scale, using the same idea as the exercise grids, and the conversation gets one overall grade: the band where most areas sit, then −, flat or +. You will get the grade and a one-line comment. This is the grid we mark with:

Band	Your analysis choices (incl. code and figures)	Your understanding of the method	Where you go next
A+	As A, and goes beyond the tasks: notices a problem in the data without being asked, and has measured it	As A, and can say what the result would look like if the method's assumptions failed	As A, and the next step would change a conclusion
A– A	Explains each choice, the alternatives and the evidence, using your own output; finds anything in your code quickly	Explains how the method works, what it assumes and when it fails; has checked it (a known answer, a plot, a second method)	A specific next step that follows from your results; says what you don't yet trust and how you'd test it
B– B B+	Explains what you did and mostly why; some choices left at defaults without comment	Explains how it works; assumptions or limits only when prompted	A sensible next step, with general reasoning
C– C C+	Describes what you did, not why; finds things in your code with difficulty	Knows what a function returns, not how or why	Next step is only "finish the tasks"
D– D D+	Can't explain your choices or find them in your code	Can't explain the method behind your code	None
F	No work of your own to discuss		

At this level D is a fail. If you have kept going with Exercise 2 and can explain your own work, you should expect B or above.

Working with friends

Talking about the exercise with others is encouraged; the work you submit, and what you explain in this conversation, must be your own. If you worked closely with someone, that's fine: we'll ask *you* to explain *your* choices. The same applies to GenAI: you must be able to explain every line you use.

Conversations happen one at a time. Please keep working at your seat until it's your turn, rather than waiting nearby, and if a conversation is happening at the next computer, carry on with your own work.

On the day

There is no sign-up: **everyone is assessed during the Week 6 lab.** Come to the lab as usual and keep working on Exercise 2 until it's your turn. **If you're working on your own laptop,** we'll call you over: bring the laptop with you. **If you're using a lab computer,** we'll come to you.

If you can't make the lab, or need a different arrangement (for example, adjustments that cover oral or in-person assessment, or a quieter room), **email Mat (mat.smith@lancaster.ac.uk) as soon as you can, and by Thursday 5 November.** He will arrange a separate session with you. If you're not sure whether this applies to you, ask Mat or Emily.

The second in-class assessment (also 5%) runs in Weeks 8–9, in the same format.